DAAD

Deutscher Akademischer Austauschdienst
German Academic Exchange Service

The German Higher Education System

An Overview



There are currently over 420 universities located throughout Germany.





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The German Higher Education System

An Overview

1st edition

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We are the DAAD

The German Academic Exchange Service (DAAD) is a joint organisation of German institutions of higher education and student bodies. Its task is to promote academic cooperation around the world, especially by awarding scholarships, developing international structures and providing expertise for academic and research collaborations. Specifically, the DAAD supports the internationalisation of German universities, promotes German studies and the German language abroad, supports countries in the Global South in building and improving their higher education systems and advises decision makers on education, foreign science and development policy.

In 2023, 141,000 students and researchers were granted the opportunity to gain international experience through DAAD funding.

You can find further detailed information about studying and living in Germany in our brochures, homepage (**www.daad.de**) and websites operated by the DAAD branch offices and Information Centres (IC).

DAAD branch offices
and Information Centres (IC)
www.daad.de/local

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HELPFUL LINKS

Universities

CHE University Ranking
www.universityranking.de

German Rectors' Conference (HRK)
www.hrk.de

Conference of Education Ministers (KMK)
www.kmk.org

German Accreditation Council
www.akkreditierungsrat.de

Studying

Comprehensive information about studying and living in Germany
www.study-in-germany.com and
www.daad.de

Degree programmes
www.myguide.de and
www.daad.de/study-programmes

International degree programmes
www.daad.de/international-programmes

Doctoral study

PhD programmes
www.phdgermany.de

Research training groups
www.dfg.de/gk

Max Planck Research Schools
www.mpg.de/en/imprs

Requirements

University entrance qualification assessment
www.anabin.de and
www.daad.de/admission-database

German test
www.testdaf.de

Visa matters
www.auswaertiges-amt.de/en/visa-service/buergerservice/faq

Scholarships
www.funding-guide.de

Research

Research organisations
www.gerit.org/en

Cutting-edge research funding
www.dfg.de/en/research-funding/funding-initiative/excellence-strategy

Research landscape
www.research-in-germany.org

Career

Sought-after professionals
www.make-it-in-germany.com

Helpful links on the German higher education system

THE GERMAN HIGHER EDUCATION SYSTEM

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Thank you for your interest in German higher education and in Germany as one of the world's top research locations. This brochure introduces you to the most important aspects and unique features of the German higher education sector.

Internationally recognised

German universities[1] enjoy an outstanding reputation around the world. This applies to its degree programmes as well as its research opportunities.

Germany is the top choice among international students after English-speaking destinations. In fact, Germany is ranked third in the world right behind the United States and Great Britain.

Germany also takes third place as the destination of choice among international researchers. Some 70,000 foreign academics currently work at German universities and other German research organisations.

Modern and innovative

German universities play a key role in driving innovation and progress. Just under 90 Nobel laureates have come from Germany, most of whom have received the Nobel Prize in chemistry, physics and medicine. Around 100 global patents are registered by researchers in Germany every day.

Centuries of success

German universities have a long and storied tradition. The world's first university was founded in Heidelberg in 1386.

Germany's modern higher education system is largely based on the ideas of Wilhelm von Humboldt (1767-1835). His vision of uniting research and instruction remains the guiding principle of German universities today.

1 Please note that if not explicitly differentiated, references to "universities" in this brochure apply equally to both comprehensive universities and universities of applied sciences (UAS).

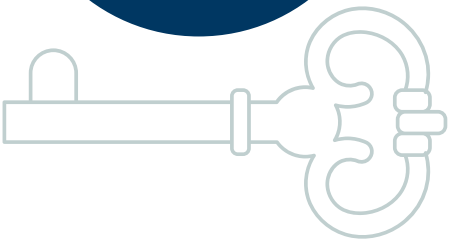
Open, fair and diverse

Freedom, respect and tolerance are key pillars of German democracy, and these values are practiced every day at universities. In recent years equal opportunity and diversity have played an increasingly important role in society and have likewise been embraced at numerous universities.

Reliable partners

German universities are highly sought-after partners in higher education alliances worldwide. They are strongly committed to building international partnerships, bilateral universities, international exchange programmes, joint courses of study and partnerships, and work hard to cultivate these close international relations.

The world's first university was founded in Heidelberg in **1386**





UNIVERSITIES: TYPES, FINANCING, QUALITY

The German higher education system is extremely diverse. There are around 430 state-accredited universities in over 180 locations throughout Germany – in metropolitan hubs, as well as small and medium-sized cities.

Diversity at the highest quality

There are three main types of universities:

- universities for general and theoretically oriented study
- universities of applied sciences (UAS) for practice-oriented study
- colleges, academies and conservatories for artistically oriented study

There are also a handful of teacher training colleges, theological universities and colleges of administrative sciences.



There are more students in **Berlin** than anywhere else – around

197,000

which is ca. 5% of the city's population

Mittweida boasts the highest proportion of students in Germany – around

6,000

which is 42.8% of the city's inhabitants

Universities and UAS in comparison

While the tradition of comprehensive universities stretches back centuries, the success story of German universities of applied sciences (UAS) only began in the 1970s.

Generally speaking, comprehensive universities specialise in basic research and cooperate with other research institutions. UAS, on the other hand, work together with regional firms and prepare students for taking up employment in certain occupations.

Compared to comprehensive universities, UAS are smaller in size. They offer fewer subjects of study and have fewer students.

At comprehensive universities, students are relatively free to design their courses of study. At UAS the degree programmes adhere to a more rigid structure, and students usually receive more intensive supervision and counselling.

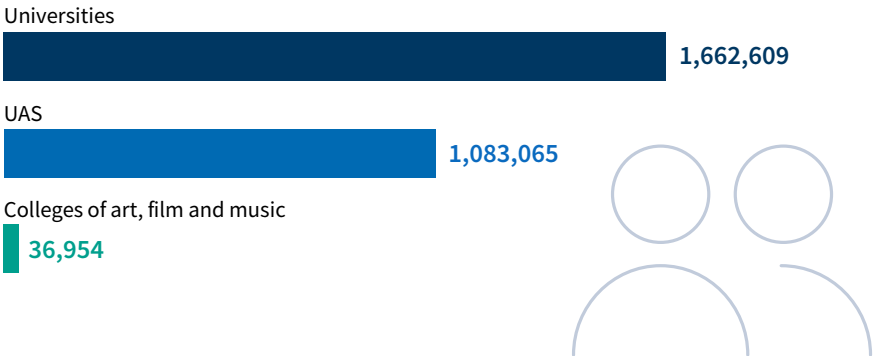
Dual study

A unique feature of German universities of applied sciences (UAS) is the "dual study" model which combines a higher education degree with on-the-job training at a company. During their studies, students are officially employed at the company and paid for their work.

UAS offer around 1,800 dual study opportunities in the disciplines of engineering, natural sciences, business, health, culture, design and social work. The majority of these are bachelor's programmes. The universities help their students find employment at a suitable company.

More and more students are showing interest in this study model which closely links theory with practice. Approximately 500,000 students are currently enrolled in dual study programmes at UAS.

Number of students



Number of universities

52
Colleges of art, film and music

109
Universities



214
German universities of applied sciences (UAS)

Financing

Almost three quarters of all universities in Germany receive public funding from the state. In addition to the 115 private universities, there are also several universities financed by the German Catholic and Protestant churches.

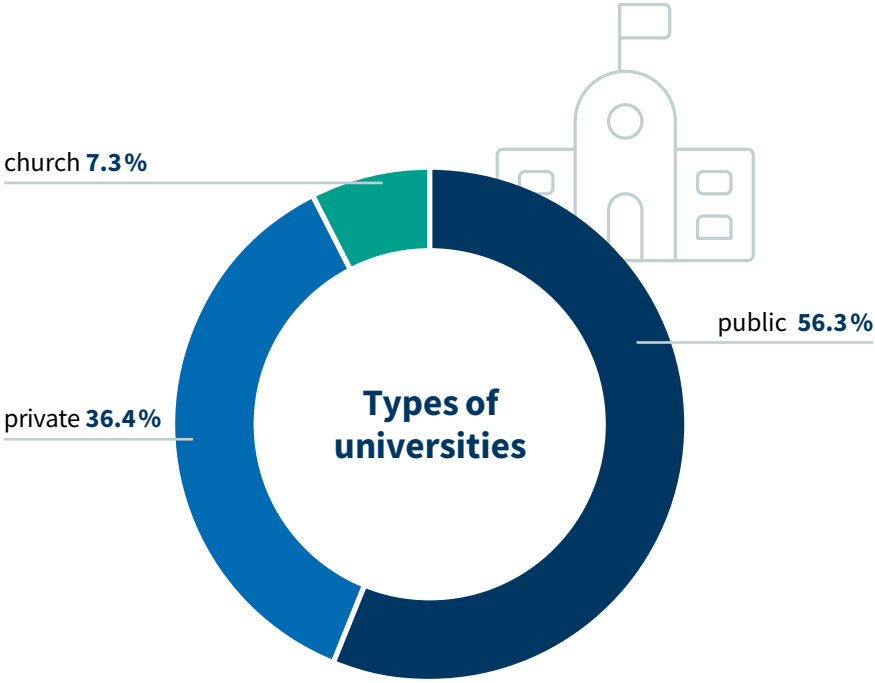
Of the total 2.9 million students in Germany, 2.5 million are enrolled in publicly funded universities. In contrast, only 365,000 students are enrolled at private universities.

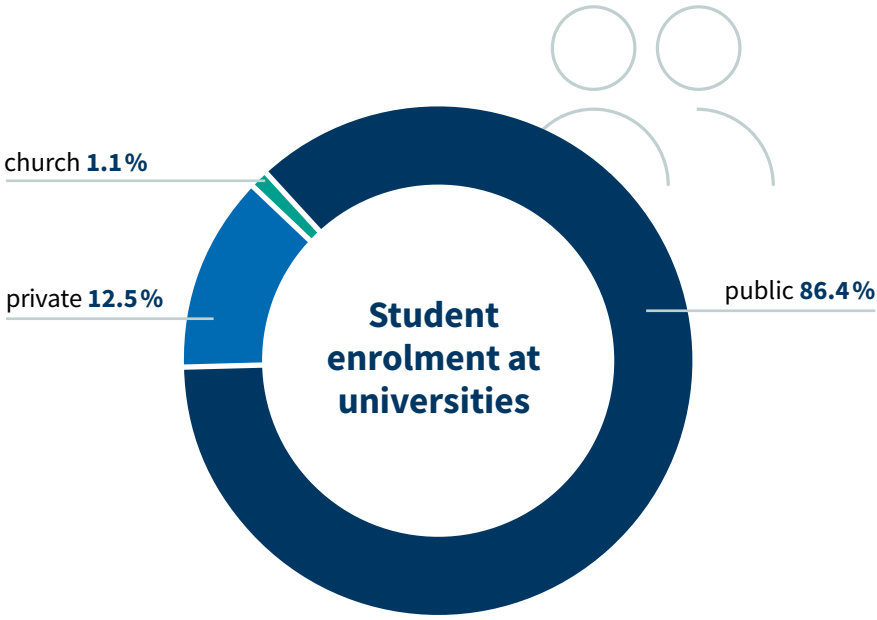
Quality and rankings

The quality of research and instruction is comparatively strong at all state-accredited universities. There is generally no difference in quality between publicly and privately funded universities. Moreover, the degree programmes meet an overall high standard of quality. Independent accreditation agencies regularly monitor and safeguard the quality of the universities and their degree programmes.

With so little difference in quality between universities, rankings have lesser significance in Germany as they do in other countries.

The CHE University Ranking is one of the more comprehensive and better-known ranking instruments. Based on the assessments of some 120,000 students and 3,000 professors, it provides information on over 40 subjects of study at almost 400 universities. For more information, visit **www.universityranking.de.**


church 7.3%
public 56.3%
private 36.4%
Types of universities


church 1.1%
private 12.5%
public 86.4%
Student enrolment at universities



HIGHER EDUCATION POLICY: FEDERAL VS. STATE RESPONSIBILITY

Germany is a federal republic; each of its 16 states has a parliament of its own. Educational policy is the responsibility of each state, which means that every state has its own higher education regulations.

Education – A state affair

The federal states enjoy broad freedom in shaping their research and higher education policies. There is, however, a national law – the German Higher Education Framework Act (HRG) – with specific rules that apply to all the federal states.

Conference of Education Ministers

The state ministers of education, science and cultural affairs regularly convene at the Conference of Education Ministers (KMK) to decide on important educational policy matters on a national scale.

German Rectors' Conference

Most German universities are members of the German Rectors' Conference (HRK). The HRK communicates the interests of the universities to policymakers and the public.

University policy

The universities are allowed to decide many policies by themselves. Consequently, not all regulations are standardised. Certain questions can only be answered by directly contacting the university of your choice.

The largest state



North Rhine-Westphalia has the most inhabitants: **18.14 million**

Bavaria is the largest state in terms of land area: **70,552 km²**



STUDY AND LEARN ON THE JOB IN GERMANY.

Say HELLO to study programmes that offer you the best of both worlds: excellent studies and gaining work experience at the same time.

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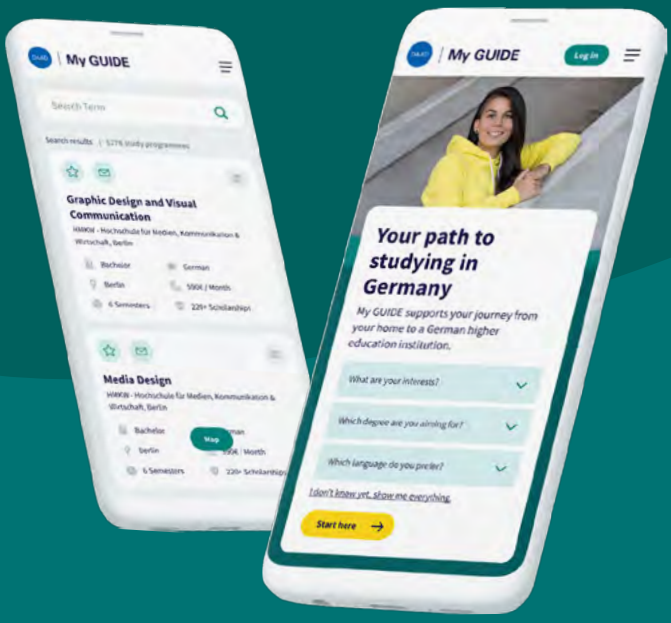
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INTERNATIONALISATION: COOPERATION AND EXCHANGE

German universities have invested heavily in internationalisation. By working closely with other institutions of higher education around the world, they facilitate exchange opportunities for their students, doctoral candidates, instructors, researchers and administrative staff.

Cooperation worldwide

Around 300 German universities have cooperation agreements with partner institutions in over 150 countries worldwide. There are meanwhile some 37,000 international agreements on academic and research collaborations with over 5,400 partners.

European Higher Education Area

Since 1999 universities in 48 European countries have been working closely to develop the European Higher Education Area. Their policies have helped standardise degree requirements and certificates and facilitated greater mobility for students and staff alike.

For over 35 years, the European Union has promoted exchange in the academic field through the Erasmus programme. Its new Erasmus+ programme is one of the most important internationalisation instruments at German universities today.

300
German universities have cooperation agreements with partner institutions in over 150 countries worldwide.

37,000
international agreements on academic and research collaborations

International students in Germany

The number of international students at German universities has increased in the past years and decades. There are now more than 367,000 international students enrolled at German universities. The share of international students at UAS is 10%, and at comprehensive universities, an impressive 14.3%.

This means that 12.6% of all students at German universities come from abroad. Over 93% of international students who enrol at a German university wish to earn a bachelor's, master's or doctoral degree here.



Rank 1: Engineering science

Rank 2: Law, economics, and social sciences

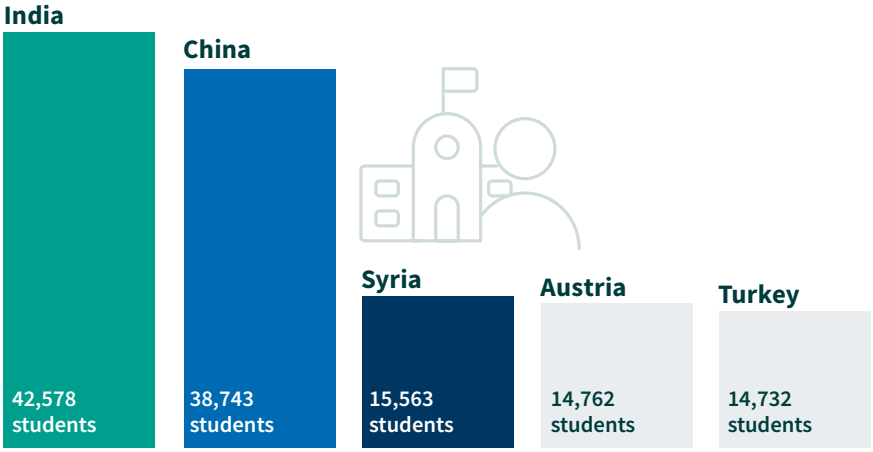
Rank 3: Mathematics and natural sciences

Rank 4: Humanities



Rank 5: Medicine and health sciences

Top 5: International students' favourite disciplines



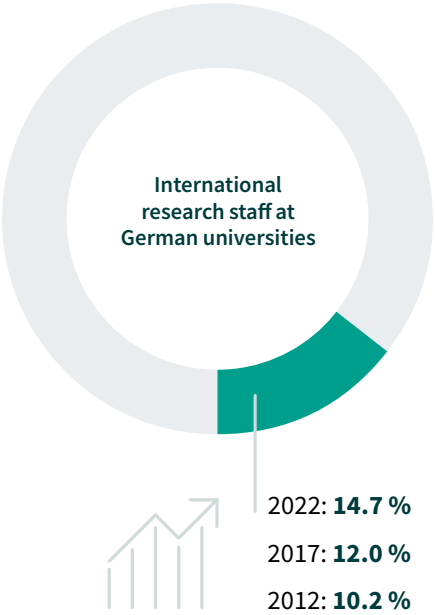
Top 5: International students' countries of origin

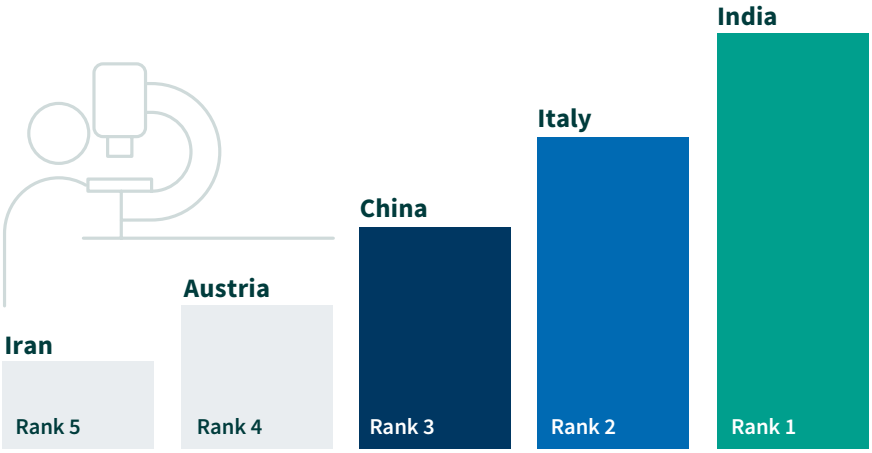
International researchers in Germany

The share of international researchers at German universities and other research organisations has also increased in recent years.

Around 63,100 academic staff with foreign citizenship are currently employed at German universities. Professors account for 3,900 of these.

There are also some 30,000 international visiting researchers teaching and conducting research at universities in Germany.





Top 5: International researchers' countries of origin



CUTTING-EDGE RESEARCH: GERMAN INSTITUTIONS OF RESEARCH EXCELLENCE

German research institutions are among the best in the world. Aside from universities and UAS, non-university-affiliated research institutes are also key players in this attractive research landscape.

Excellence Strategy for cutting-edge research

German federal and state governments have launched a special funding programme to actively support cutting-edge research at German universities. Its goal is to further strengthen the German research sector on the international stage.

The programme grants funding to single or multiple universities to create Clusters of Excellence in internationally competitive research fields where researchers from various disciplines and institutions can collaborate on joint research ventures.

The programme also provides targeted funding to ten universities and one consortium which have been distinguished as 'Universities of Excellence':

- RWTH Aachen University
- Berlin consortium (Freie Universität Berlin, Humboldt Universität, TU Berlin, Charité)
- University of Bonn
- TU Dresden
- University of Hamburg
- Heidelberg University
- Karlsruhe Institute of Technology (KIT)
- University of Konstanz
- LMU Munich
- TU Munich
- University of Tübingen

Max Planck Society: Germany‘s most successful research organisation - with 31 Nobel Prize winners.

Non-university research organisations

The German research landscape is not only comprised of well-equipped universities, but also non-university-affiliated research institutes which enjoy an outstanding reputation around the world. The best known institutions include:

- Fraunhofer Society
- Helmholtz Association
- Leibniz Association

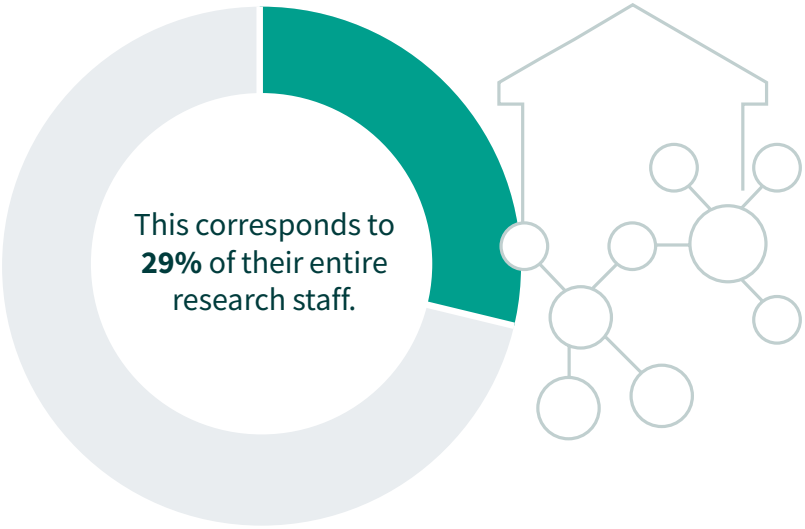
These organisations run numerous research institutes in Germany and operate branches around the world. For a complete list of German research locations in Germany and abroad, visit **www.gerit.org**.

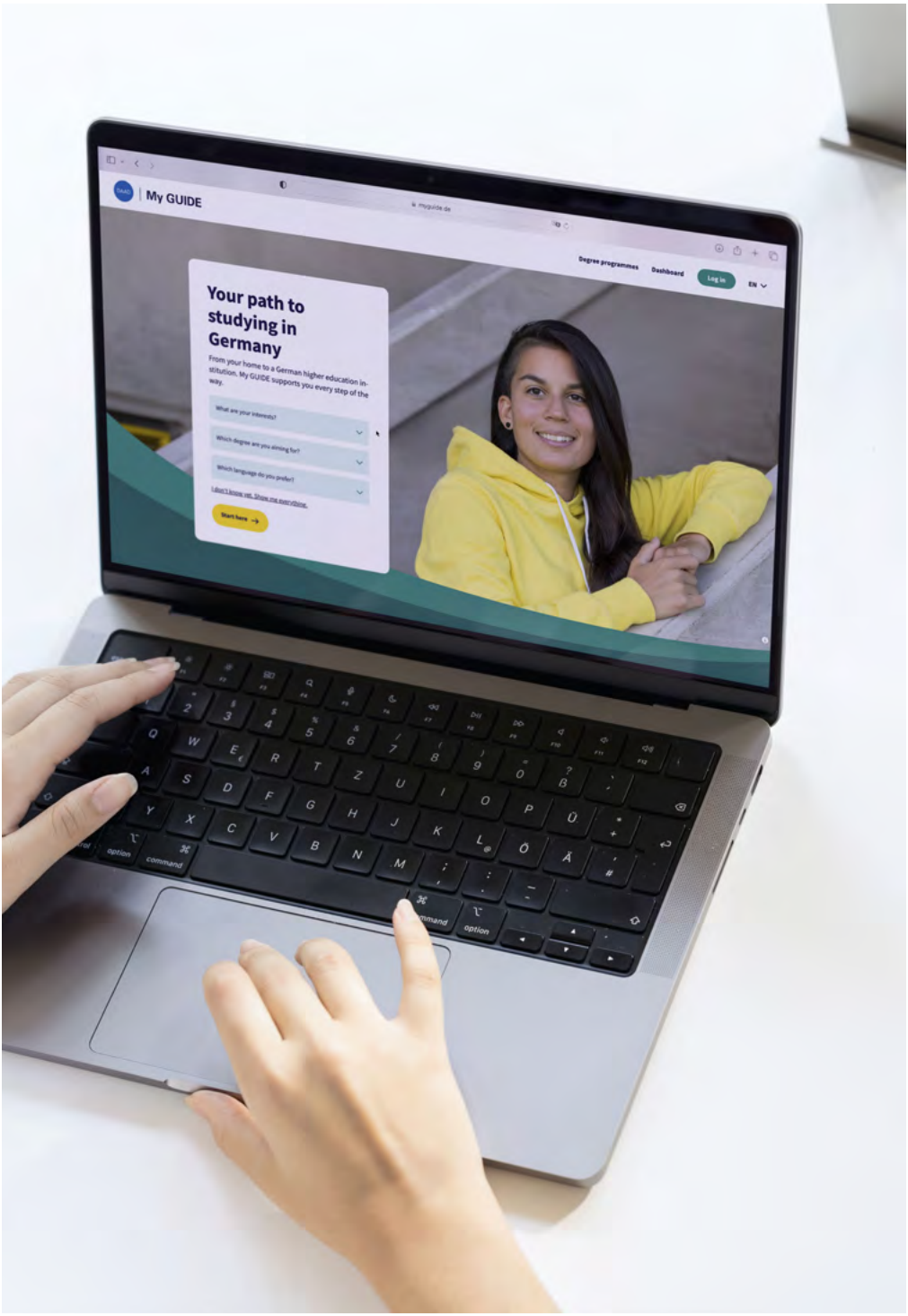
Even non-university research organisations are internationalising their efforts more than ever. The number of international researchers working at such organisations practically doubled between 2012 and 2021. Some 15,900 international researchers work there today, equivalent to around 29% of their entire research staff.



Some **15,900** international researchers work there today

Non-university research organisations




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EN
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From your home to a German higher education institution. My GUIDE supports you every step of the way.
What are your interests?
Which degree are you aiming for?
Which language do you prefer?
I don't know yet. Show me everything.
Start here
option
command
option

STUDY OPPORTUNITIES: PROGRAMMES AND DEGREES

German universities offer study opportunities that cater to a diverse array of interests, wishes and levels of education.

Broad range of programmes

There are around 22,000 courses of study offered in Germany. More than 11,500 of these are for first-time students (bachelor's programmes), while over 10,500 are for advanced study (master's and doctoral programmes).

More than 10% of all degree programmes have an international orientation. These include almost all English-language bachelor's, master's and PhD programmes. You can find information on some 2,300 international degree programmes on the online database **www.daad.de/international-programmes.**

Studying online

Public and private universities alike offer numerous online and distance learning courses. There are over 1,000 online degree programmes currently available, some of which are international in scope. In some cases, participants are required to pay course fees.



To search for a specific degree programme, visit **www.daad.de/study-programmes** or **www.myguide.de**

Internationally recognised degrees

German universities offer varying courses of study with different academic degrees.

Bachelor's degree (BA, BSc, …)

- 1st academic qualification
- 6- to 8-semester undergraduate study programme

Master's degree (MA, MSc, …)

- 2nd academic qualification (following successful completion of a bachelor's degree)
- 2- to 4-semester advanced study programme

State examination

- State certificate
- Only in the subjects of medicine, pharmacy, law and all teaching degree programmes

Diplom

- Academic degree equivalent to a master's degree
- Awarded in a few, mostly engineering-related degree programmes

Doctorate

- Academic degree after earning a master's, state examination or Diplom from a university or UAS
- Conferral of the doctoral title
- 4- to 10-semester programme, concluding with an independent research project or written dissertation

Two paths to a doctorate

German universities offer post-graduates attractive doctoral study opportunities. There are basically two options:

1 Individual doctoral study

Doctoral candidates work independently on a research project (= dissertation). They must first convince a professor (= doctoral supervisor) of their qualifications and the merit of their research proposal.

2 Structured PhD programme

Candidates enrol in an established PhD programme. Research training groups and graduate schools are two examples of such programmes.

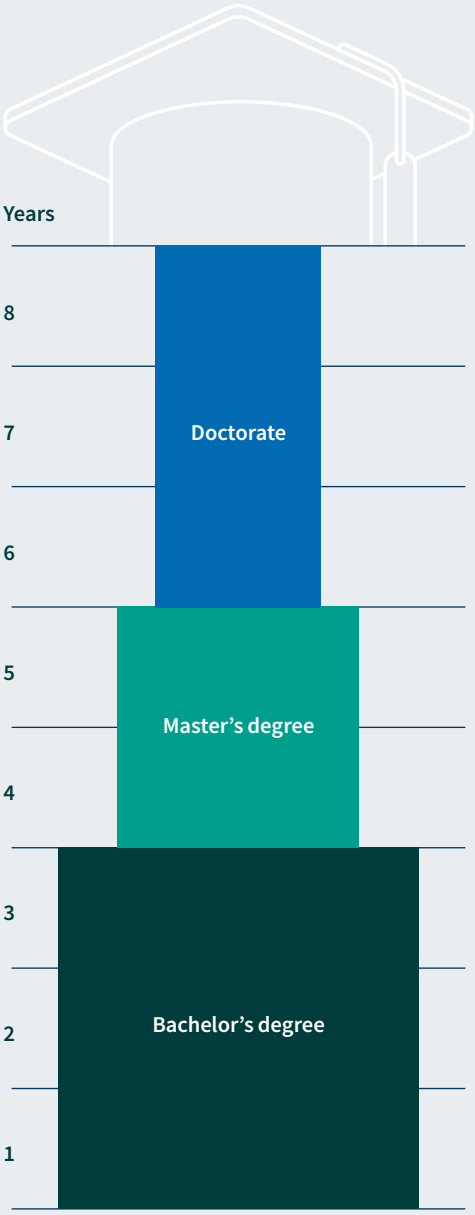
Research training groups are short-term research projects conducted at universities. The dissertations usually have an interdisciplinary focus and are written in collaboration with other researchers.

For a list of research training groups funded by the German Research Foundation (DFG), visit **www.dfg.de/gk.**

Graduate schools and international doctoral programmes are tailored to the needs of international PhD students and are usually conducted in English.

Such programmes are offered at universities or research organisations, e.g. at almost 70 International Max Planck Research Schools (IMPRS) – **www.mpg.de/en/imprs.**

Half of all German states have meanwhile passed legislation granting universities of applied sciences (UAS) the right to award doctoral degrees.





STUDYING IN GERMANY: REQUIREMENTS AND SERVICES

German universities offer optimal conditions for obtaining an excellent education with comprehensive supervision.

Eligibility and admission requirements

If you wish to study in Germany, you must hold a "university entrance qualification". This could be, for example, a secondary school-leaving certificate or an undergraduate degree. You can find an overview of foreign certificates recognised in Germany as university entrance qualifications at: **www.daad.de/admission-database**.

Universities are allowed to set their own admission requirements for prospective students. Especially for master's degree programmes, each university can decide which qualifications or test results are required for admission.

Therefore, if you're interested in a specific degree programme, contact the university of your choice in advance for information on their admission regulations.

Language skills

The level of language proficiency that students require depends on their choice of degree programme:

- International degree programmes: good English language skills
- All other degree programmes: good German language skills

There are several standardised tests that can certify your German language ability, e.g. TestDaF, the Test of German as a Foreign Language – **www.testdaf.de.** For more information, visit **www.daad.de/german-language.**

Entry visas

As an international student, you may require an entry visa depending on your country of origin.

Citizens of EU countries, Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland do not require an entry visa.

Citizens from outside the EU should contact the German embassy or consulate in their home country or visit **www.auswaertiges-amt.de/en/visa-service/buergerservice/ faq** for information on specific entry requirements.

Financing

International students must provide proof that they can finance their study visit in Germany on their own. At present, international students must show that they have more than €992 per month, or €11,904 per year at their disposal (as of Jan. 2025). This statement is called the *Finanzierungsnachweis*, or proof of financial resources.

Tuition fees

The majority of students in Germany attend public universities which offer free tuition for most bachelor's and master's degree programmes.

There are exceptions, however. In the state of Baden-Württemberg, non-EU citizens are required to pay €1,500 in tuition each semester (= ½ year), but foreign doctoral candidates do not. For more information, contact the university of your choice.

In all German states, there are certain master's programmes that require tuition fees – in most cases more than €10,000 per semester. Private universities tend to charge relatively high tuition fees, as well.

Scholarships

There is a wide range of funding opportunities for international students interested in studying in Germany. Most scholarships are awarded by funding organisations and foundations.

Some universities also offer scholarships of their own, e.g. the Deutschlandstipendium. However, German universities generally award fewer scholarships than universities in other countries.

For a comprehensive overview of the funding opportunities available to international students, visit the DAAD scholarship database **www.funding-guide.de.**



International Office

There is an International Office at every university where international students can receive help with all their questions.

The International Office can advise you on university-specific study opportunities and admission requirements, and provide meaningful assistance ahead of your arrival, for example, with finding accommodation.

You can find further information on planning a study visit in Germany at **www.study-in-germany.com.**

Other services

There is a broad range of other services and programmes that support international students during their stay in Germany. These include buddy programmes, language tandems, sport courses and psychological health services.

Universities also support students in special circumstances, e.g. students with children of their own, or students with physical impairments.

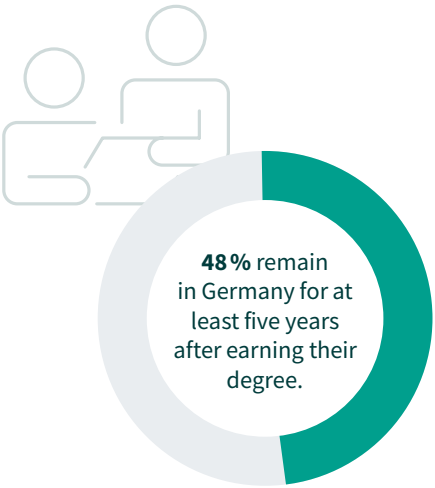
At some universities the International Office is called **“Akademisches Auslandsamt“** or **“Internationales Büro“.**



CAREER: PROSPECTS AND LEGAL CONDITIONS

Germany is one of the world's most attractive destinations for launching one's career following graduation.

There are multiple reasons for this, including Germany's high-quality employment opportunities, living standards, level of safety, innovative potential and universal health care system.

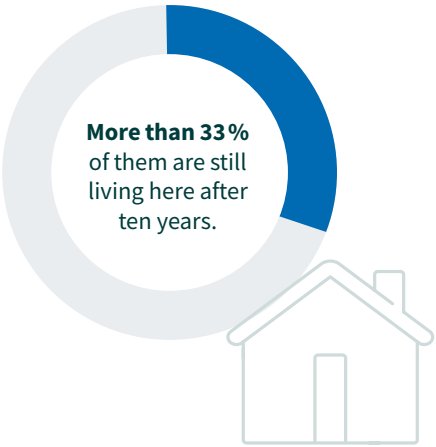


Wanted: Highly skilled professionals

After completing your studies at a German university, your chances of staying and working in Germany are promising.

Like in many other countries, German employers struggle to find highly skilled professionals. Especially in the fields of mathematics, computer science, natural sciences, engineering and medicine, there is an acute shortage of highly qualified workers.

In fact, 48% of international students remain in Germany for at least five years after earning their degree. More than one third of them are still living here after ten years.



Legal conditions

The legal conditions pertaining to university graduates from non-EU countries have significantly improved in recent years. After receiving your degree, you have 18 months to find a job that corresponds to your professional qualification. Those who manage to find employment can remain in Germany – and have good chances of obtaining a permanent residence visa.

Legal conditions have significantly improved in recent years

1.5 years

to find a job that corresponds to your professional qualification

12.6%

of all students come **from another country** to study at a German university



There are now more than

367,000

international students

enrolled at German universities.